



OIL

In the rocks under hot deserts, snowy plains, and stormy seas, there is buried treasure: a “liquid gold” called oil. Most of this sticky, black fossil fuel is used for energy, but 12 percent of each barrel is turned into chemicals and plastics. All oil is brought to the

Sandstone

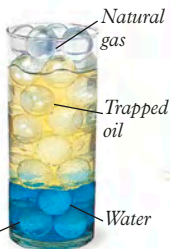


Sandstone with oil

Solid “sponge”

Oil is found in the tiny spaces in rocks such as sandstone. This oily layer is often sandwiched between water and a layer of natural gas.

Each marble stands for a grain of rock.



A boring bit

A sharp-toothed metal cutter, called a bit, bores through rock to reach oil. Drill bits are replaced twice a day, as they wear out quickly.



During drilling, chemicals are pumped around the bit to carry rubble up to the surface.

This is a model of an oil platform in the North Sea.

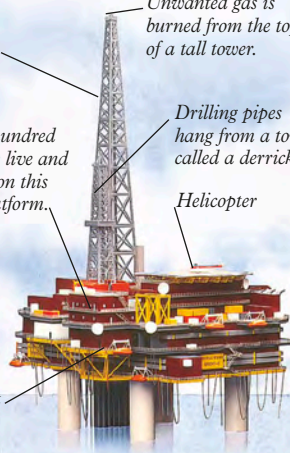
Unwanted gas is burned from the top of a tall tower.

Two hundred people live and work on this oil platform.

Drilling pipes hang from a tower called a derrick.

Helicopter

Lifeboat



Every day, one quarter of a million barrels of hot, freshly drilled oil are pumped into the hollow concrete legs to cool down.

Some oil is piped into a gigantic, underwater storage tank.

Cooled oil is piped ashore.

Explosives are used to make cracks in the rock so that oil can flow into the wells.

Gas

An arched layer of oilproof rock, such as granite, traps oil underneath it.

Oil

Water

Wells fan out to reach the oil.

